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The Next time you Fly, The Internet will Fly too..

Today, we take Internet access for granted. Many of us need Net access as much as we need phones, or even more. I personally check e-mail several times a day. One of my friends, a pioneer in computing, wakes up after 3 hours of sleep, checks his mail and then goes back to sleep. We get a little nervous when we haven't checked mail for over a day.

Business travelers have always been worried about connectivity, especially on long flights. Sometimes events require split second decisions. For example, stockbrokers or fund managers, feel the need to be reachable during market hours, to receive information and react to it. But, once a flight takes off, you can't do any of this.

Until recently, there wasn't an option, even if you carried your cell phone or laptop. Due to technological developments and the competitive nature of the travel industry, you can now get varying degrees of Internet access on flights and cruises.

For over two years, certain cruise lines in the Caribbean have been providing Net access at a cost of \$1 per minute. Many companies are wiring up entire ships, with Ethernet access in every cabin. Norwegian Cruise Lines has a ship called Norwegian Sky which offers this facility.

On-flight Internet is the number one demand by business travellers, and is slowly becoming a reality, with two main players offering viable options.

Connexion, by Boeing offers broadbandbased connectivity. For this, an airline has to tie up with Connexion and aircrafts are retrofitted with two Ku band antennae—one for downlink, and one for uplink. The antennae electronically scan for satellites, which they connect to overhead servers and Wi-Fi antennas. The result is an operational satellite network with a 5 Mbps downlink and a 256 Kbps uplink. Current antennae do not function north of 75 degrees latitude, which is a problem being tackled by Mitsubishi Electronics.

Current test systems send data at

128 Kbps and receive at 3 Mbps, with production models estimated to have a 1 Mbps send and 20 Mbps receive capability.

Currently, trials of this service are underway with Lufthansa and British Airways on certain Boeing 747-400 aircrafts. Lufthansa calls it FlyNet, and is available on the Frankfurt to Dulles flight, while British Airways offers it on its Heathrow to JFK flight. Lufthansa is offering FlyNet free during the test period for Business, First class and some Economy class seats, but plan to charge \$ 30 afterwards. British Airways, is offering this service only in Business and First class, and charges \$ 30 during trial.

Tenzing Communications Inc, a Seattle-based company is another player with a different approach to the connectivity problem, and is far ahead in terms of deployment. Airbus, a Boeing competitor, is a strategic investor in Tenzing. Tenzing service offers only filtered e-mail connectivity. It partners with various smaller ISPs on the ground to give you seamless connectivity, even North of 75 degree latitude. You can connect your laptop and access POP3 accounts and select Web mail providers, such as Hotmail, or use entertainment screens in front of every seat to send SMSs to any mobile phone. It's already deployed on 40 out of 80 Cathay Pacific planes. This facility is also available on Virgin Atlantic flights, with a low cost per user of \$ 10.

Tenzing expects it to be viable if 3 per cent of passengers use this service. Their approach is to use existing infrastructure—airline communication antennae and entertainment screens—to provide basic e-mail access, as research proved that e-mail is given more importance than Web access by travelers. This system can also be upgraded to support broadband access, as and when the market demands it. This is cheaper, as airlines don't have to retrofit new antennas or lose revenue due to installation time.

Boeing expects to equip 250 aircrafts with this service in the next 2 years, and 4,000 in the next 7 years. ■

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